who then further elect the CWC elite from that pool.

While this is the procedure on paper, the rebels claim that, in practice, the CEA, in consultation with the central party leadership, prepares the lists of PCC delegates and AICC members and gets them signed by the respective state presidents. The party president and CWC members are then elected based on it. This is why the G18 members are demanding an overhaul of the election process. "The process is rigged to elect a Gandhi as president and a group of clowns as CWC members," says a Congress MP from Punjab.

That's why the real objective of the G18 is to ensure that the election to the CWC does not sideline those who don't have Rahul's backing. Elected CWC members can strongly oppose the decisions of the president as they are not there at his/her mercy. So even if a Gandhi is the next president, the arbitrary and whimsical ways of running the party will end.

In nearly half a century, CWC elections have been held only twice—in 1992 and 1997. On both occasions, a non-Gandhi was at the helm. Since Sonia Gandhi took charge, she has been nominating CWC members. The last time she recast the CWC was in September 2020, a month after the G23 letter. Three of the original G23 leaders—Azad, Anand Sharma and Wasnik—retained their positions in the CWC. In response to the demand for collective leadership, she even formed a six-member panel to assist her and included Wasnik as a member. Since then, he has distanced himself from the rebels.

Can G18 Dethrone the Gandhis?

Family loyalists assert that the Congress has always practised collective leadership and dismiss the rebel allegations as a "bogus claim". Seven of the G18 leaders are part of multiple Congress committees, they point out. Azad was the general secretary in-charge and former chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda was campaign committee chief during the assembly election in Haryana in 2020. Former Maharashtra chief minister Prithviraj Chavan was screening committee chief for the 2021 Assam poll.

The G18 leaders counter this, saying such occasional assignments (with many restraints) don't amount to collective leadership, which is a "continuous process". One of them points out how Sharma is rarely consulted on the India-China conflict though he heads the foreign affairs department. "Find out how many times the six-member committee to assist Sonia Gandhi has met in the past two years. All decisions are taken by the Gandhi siblings based on their personal likes and dislikes, which then gets the stamp of their mother," says a Rajya Sabha member.

The G18 leaders have been ridiculed as leaders past their prime without mass or organisational appeal and who are seeking official positions of influence, including accommodation in the Rajya Sabha. Azad lost his RS membership last year. Sharma, Sibal and Vivek Tankha will lose their seats by July and are unlikely to be re-elected. Azad has not contested a Lok Sabha poll since 1984. Sharma has never contested one. Sibal and Tankha have lost multiple times. Mani Shankar Aiyar lost his deposit in 2014 and Shankersinh Vaghela is not even a Congress member (he quit in 2017).

However, there are others among them who enjoy mass support. For instance, Shashi Tharoor has won three consecutive Lok Sabha polls, Tewari is a two-time Lok Sabha MP. Hooda, a stalwart of Haryana politics, is leader of the Opposition in the state assembly. "Any of them can contest election to the post of president if there is a free and fair poll," says a G18 leader. But any chance of rejigging the electoral process is lost without the support of senior leaders such as Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot, Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel and MP stalwarts Kamal Nath and Digvijaya Singh. Gehlot and Baghel have stood firmly behind the Gandhis while Nath and Digvijaya are focused on winning back MP. In December 2020, Nath brokered a temporary peace between some of the rebels and Sonia. This time, he has stayed silent.

Meanwhile, the process to divide the G18—the way it was done two years ago—has begun. Rahul reached out to Hooda and there is speculation that if his son Deepender is made president of Haryana Congress, the ex-CM may exit the rebel team. Sonia met some rebels leaders too in batches—first Azad and then Sharma, Tewari and Tankha together.

What worries the Rahul acolytes is a situation where they may need to find a 'dummy' candidate, if he decides not to contest the presidential poll. This is a situation even the rebel leaders are anticipating. Two of the most speculated about names are from Rajasthan—CM Gehlot and his chief detractor, Sachin Pilot. Both have shown little interest in leading the sinking ship, though the Family has in the past tried to convince Gehlot to take the post. ■

IN NEARLY HALF A CENTURY, CWC ELECTIONS HAVE BEEN HELD ONLY TWICE: IN 1992 AND 1997. ON BOTH OCCASIONS, A NON-GANDHI WAS AT THE HELM. SINCE SONIA GANDHI TOOK CHARGE, SHE HAS BEEN NOMINATING CWC MEMBERS